

1/2 pg V AD

Silver has to be handed out to the ASUS DRW-1604P for an overall score of 69.90. Lite-On's SOHW-1633S gets a consolation prize for extremely good

pricing, together with a decent performance. If your budget is too tight for the Pioneer or the ASUS, the Lite-On is for you.



The ASUS DRW-1604P

External DVD Writers

Mobility in backup solutions is an important aspect to consider. With an external DVD writer, the process of backing up becomes more efficient as it only involves unplugging the device from one machine and plugging it into another.

You do not need to shutdown the machine(s) in question, since these are all USB or FireWire-enabled devices. Additionally, if you plan to copy data from one machine and burn it on another, you save time otherwise spent waiting for data transfers over the network. You can travel around with an external burner, effortlessly plugging it into any capable system and getting the data out when you need it.

We had two external DVD burners from Plextor, and one each from Iomega and AOpen.

Features

The Plextor burners were USB 2.0/FireWire versions of the exact same drives that we tested in the single-layer internal category: the PX-708UF and the PX-712UF, where UF stands for "USB2.0/FireWire." The A in the single-layer internals stands for "ATAPI." The specs of the PX-712UF were obviously the same: 12X DVD+R, 8X DVD-R, and 48X CD-R, which was the best in the category. The Iomega drive was up to par with DVD speeds, and almost there with 40X CD-R writing. But it was the only drive capable of burning dual-layered DVD+Rs.

The AOpen lost out because of its 2.4X DVD+R speeds, and again, no DVD-R support. Also, the CD-R speed was the lowest in the whole range including the single-layer drives—only 12X. However, it came with the best bundle—a DVD+R, DVD+RW,



The Speed Trap

For regular optical CDs, you have speeds going from 1X all the way to 52X. But for CD-RW media, we have speed "brackets," and they are named accordingly. As of now there are four types of CD-RWs available:

- Multi Speed: 1X - 4X
- High Speed: 4X - 12X
- Ultra Speed: 16X - 24X
- Ultra Speed+: 24X - 32X

Burners have to support that speed to be able to burn on a CD-RW disk from that bracket. If the CD-RW is rated higher, your burner may not be able to write to it. You can still read the disks, though. All the DVD burners we tested are UltraSpeed compatible, but only a few—such as the Pioneer, ASUS, BenQ and the Iomega—support UltraSpeed+ CD-RW, albeit only at 24X.